The rest of this paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 documents the power of the T5 in determining tenure and the time-to-tenure. Section 3 reports responses to a survey of junior faculty about their perceptions of current tenure and promotion practices. They are consistent with the evidence from our empirical analysis. Section 4 examines the quality of the T5 filter as measured by citations to papers published there. Section 5 presents evidence on editorial tenure length in house journals and on incest.

The paper concludes with a summary. We discuss what – if anything – should be done about the practice of relying on T5 publications. We use an online appendix[15] to present background information and to report sensitivity analyses. We attach a within-text-Appendix to explain certain points of methodology.

We note at the outset what this paper *does not* do. It does not offer an empirical assessment of whether current incentives in economics lead to meritocratic outcomes in academic economics. To do so would require an accurate measure of academic productivity and research quality that do not yet exist. We rely on citation counts as a crude proxy for productivity and quality, noting that the measure is flawed but conventional. We also do not prove that the incentives we measure lead young economists to focus on pursuing those incentives. We document certain strong incentives built into the current tenure and promotion system and presume that junior academics respond to them just as agents would respond to incentives in the models we teach and in the data we study.

2 Empirical Evidence on the Potency of the Top Five

This section presents an extensive analysis of the basis for incentives facing young economists. Publication in T5 journals is the path to success. We note at the outset that finance has emerged as a major field that abuts economics and has many influential scholars. In our main analyses we pool papers in finance along with those in other fields of economics. Online Appendix Section 5 conducts a parallel analysis excluding papers in finance. Our point

[15] See http://heckman.uchicago.edu/publishing-and-promotion/appendix.pdf

estimates are barely affected. Under either treatment of data, we document that publication in the T5 is an important predictor of professional success.

2.1 Data

We investigate the relationship between tenure decisions and T5 publications using panel data on the job and publication histories of tenure-track faculty hired by the top 35 U.S. economics departments between the years 1996 and 2010. Panel data are constructed in four steps.[16] Online Appendix Section 1 describes details on how we construct our data.

Tenure rates by the end of the first spell vary between 26% and 31% across the department groupings, and do not exhibit systematic differences with respect to department ranking.[17] Not surprisingly, a substantial percentage of junior faculty move downwards.[18] The incidence of lateral movement is highest among the top five departments with a rate of 21%. It is lowest for departments ranked 26 to 35 with a rate of 6%. Conversely, upward movement and exits to industry are more common among lower ranked departments, and become less frequent for higher-ranked departments.[19] Tenure rates are considerably higher at the end of the second spell across all department rank groupings, with tenure rates ranging from 34% to 54%.[20,21]

[16]The four steps are: (i) construction of a roster of tenure-track faculty hired by the top 35 departments between 1996 and 2010 using publicly available historical snapshots of departmental websites archived by WayBackMachine; (ii) construction of work histories for tenure-track faculty using CVs and other public sources of work-history data; (iii) construction of tenure decisions based on multiple sources of publicly available information including official announcements of tenure conferral; and (iv) construction of publication and citation profiles using data from Scopus.com.

[17]See Online Appendix Table O-A4

[18]The top 5 departments exhibit the largest difference between the percentage of downward movers and the percentage of tenure recipients. This discrepancy in relative differences arises partly because faculty at the top 5 departments are unable to move upwards by definition, thereby restricting their outcome destinations to 4 options instead of 5.

[19]Rates of upward and lateral movement combined are similar across all rank groups.

[20]See Online Appendix Table O-A6 for tenure rates during the second spell.

[21]Online Appendix Table O-A7 gives estimates for rates of tenure conferral for the top 35 departments.

Figure 1: Length of First Tenure-Track Employment by Tenure Outcome

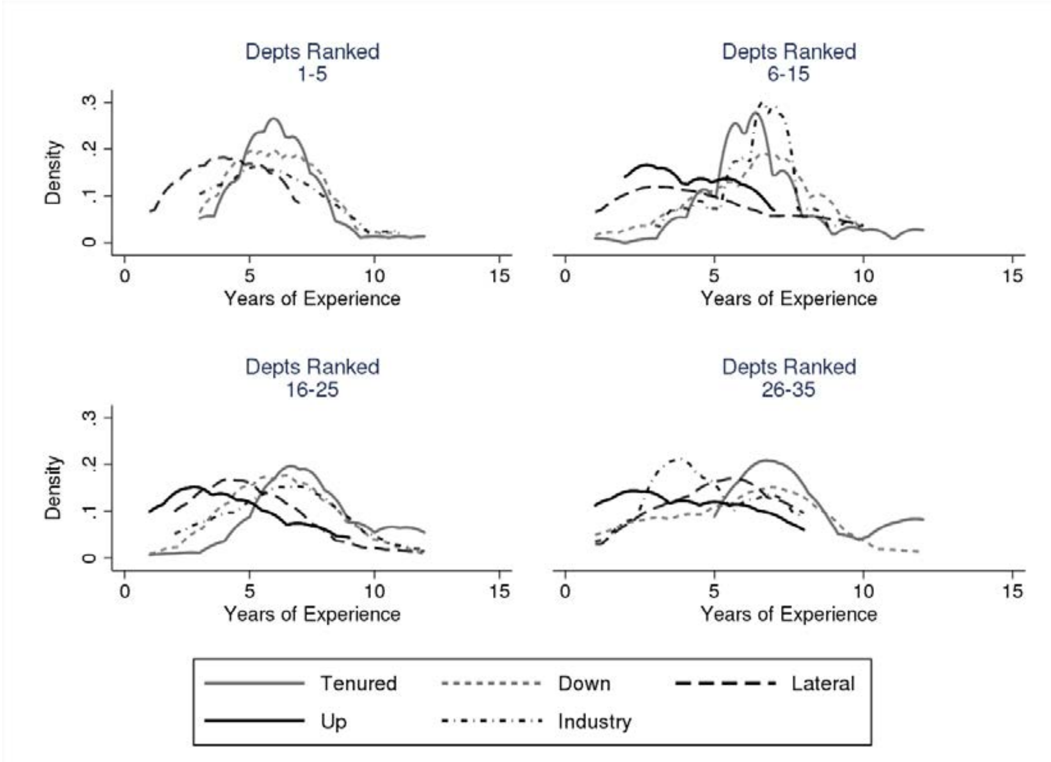


Figure 1 plots department rank-specific distributions for the length of first tenure-track employment for individuals who received tenure or moved to other opportunities following the first spell of tenure-track employment. The distributions for tenure recipients have means between 5.4 and 7.0 years and standard deviations between 2.0 and 3.0 years.[22,23] The distributions for upward and lateral departmental movements are left-shifted relative to the tenured distributions. In comparison, the distributions for downward movement and exits to industry are more similar to the tenured distributions. These differences suggest that downward movements and movements to industry are more likely to result from denial of tenure, compared to upward and lateral movements which tend to occur considerably earlier than receipt of tenure. We discuss differences by gender in Section 2.4.

[22]See Online Appendix Table O-A5 for means and standard deviations corresponding to each group

[23]The right tails for the tenured distributions extend beyond 10 years. The presence of such outliers is consistent with what one would expect given the adoption of tenure clock extension policies that allow faculty to extend the length of tenure clocks in the event of pregnancies, adoptions, and other permissible circumstances.

2.1.1 Categorizing the Journals

To compare the relationships between tenure decisions and publications in T5 and non-T5 journals, we categorize non-T5 journals into "quality" categories. Such categorization allows us to estimate the influence on tenure of publishing in non-T5 journals of similar standing. We use the field-specific rankings of Combes and Linnemer (2010) to categorize journals into the following groups: Tier A Field, Tier B Field, and non-T5 general interest.[24] Online Appendix Table O-A9 presents the journals in these categories.

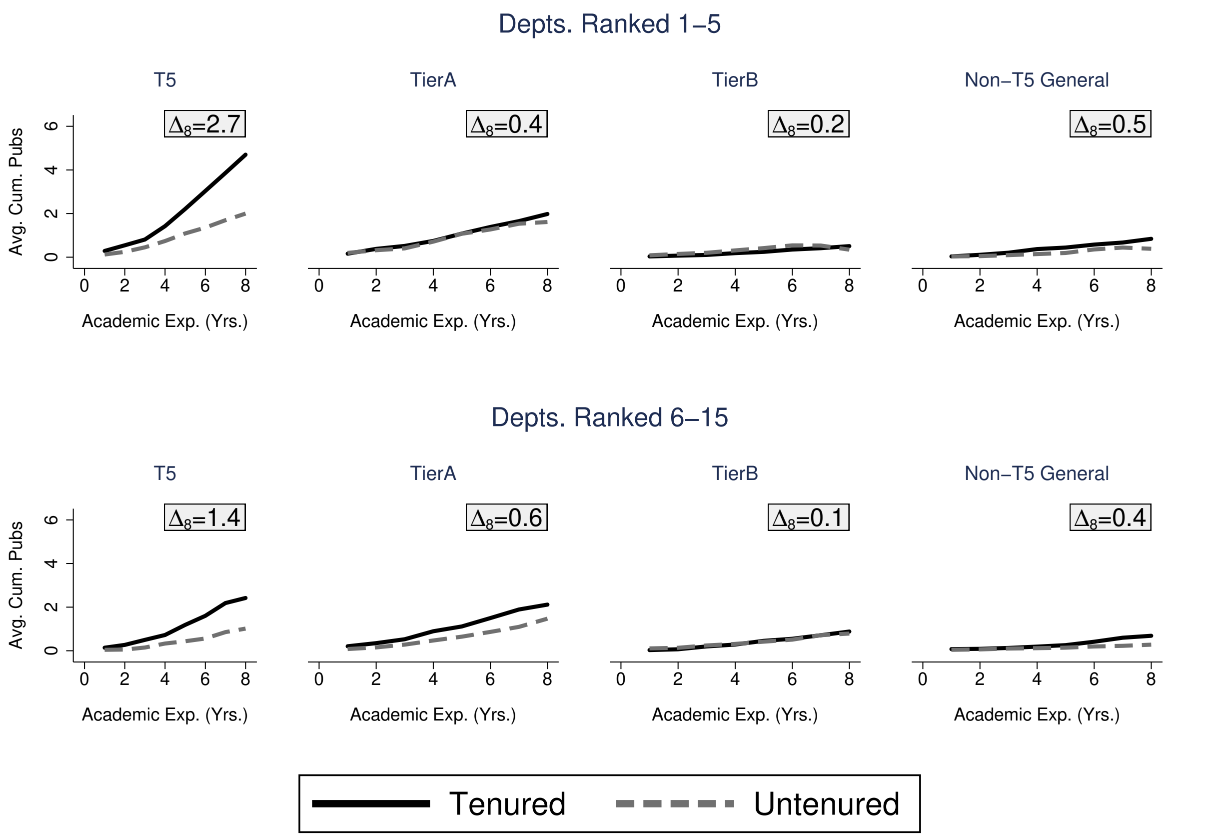
A summary of the publications data follows. Figure 2 differentiates faculty in the top 15 departments by tenure decision, and plots mean publication counts in the four journal categories over the first eight years of academic experience.[25] The plots reveal a striking pattern. In terms of research productivity in peer-reviewed journals, tenured faculty at the top 5 departments differentiate themselves from their tenure-denied colleagues primarily based on T5 publications. The evolution of T5 publications exhibits considerable separation between tenured and tenure-denied faculty, with the average publication count reaching a difference of almost 3 publications by the 8^{th} year of academic experience. The stark difference in separation between the T5 and non-T5 journals strongly suggests that top departments place a disproportionately large emphasis on T5 publications.

The degree of T5 differentiation falls among departments ranked 6 to 15. This decrease in T5 separation is accompanied by an increase in separation for Tier A Field journals, with differences in average publication counts in Tier A journals as of the 8^{th} year increasing from 0.4 for the top 5 departments to 0.6 for departments ranked 6 to 15. Despite these changes, the T5 continues to serve as the main differentiator between tenured and tenure-denied faculty among departments ranked 6 to 15. The relative importance of Tier A journals continues to increase as we consider lower ranked departments, with the separation

[24]Tier A Field consists of the two highest-ranked journals in the fields of development, econometrics, finance, microeconomics/game theory, health economics, industrial organization, labor economics, macroeconomics and public economics. Tier B Field is composed of journals ranked three to five in the same fields. The non-T5 general interest category includes the five highest ranked non-T5 general interest journals.

[25]See Online Appendix Figure O-A1 for plots corresponding to departments ranked 16–35.

Figure 2: Evolution of Average Publication Portfolios by Tenure Outcome and by Departmental Ranks



Note: This figure plots the evolution of average publications in four different journal categories by tenure outcome. The plotted means are calculated over tenure-track faculty hired by departments belonging to the referenced department rank-group. Δ_8 denotes differences in average cumulative publications as of year 8 between the tenured and untenured groups.

for Tier A journals surpassing the separation for T5 journals among departments ranked 16 to 25.

The observed pattern of publication behavior suggests that the number of T5 publications required for tenure decreases with department ranking. Non-T5 publications are valued more at lower ranked schools. Faculty at lower ranked departments can publish more non-T5 articles to compensate for their lower T5 publications. This evidence of heterogeneity suggests that it might be informative to conduct a deeper examination of department rank-based heterogeneity in the relationship between tenure decisions and publications. In our formal analysis, we use econometric models that allow for such heterogeneity.